

Chapter 118_3 - Bastard

"Jiang Li doesn't know what kind of treatment she's suffering right now. You must know that those people from Penglai appear righteous on the surface, but their methods are extremely cruel," Ning Fuyi said alarmingly. "I heard that woman seems to be a snake demon. Is that true or false?"

Jiang Wuying turned her head away displeasedly, which was as good as admitting it.

"Then it's true." Ning Fuyi nodded, then turned to look at Chu Qingqiu, her gaze softening somewhat. "Look, does this shape resemble a snake?"

Chu Qingqiu widened her eyes slightly: "Indeed it does."

"That demon has long been dead - how could it be related to her?" Jiang Wuying snorted. "Back then, that demon seduced Jiang'er into committing great wrongs and was hunted by the immortal sects to the Eastern Wasteland¹, where it was finally eliminated. Its bones have probably turned to ash long ago."

Ning Fuyi clenched her fists and looked toward Chu Qingqiu.

"So when you originally arranged a marriage for Jiang Li and specifically chose men, it was because..."

"I've lived these several hundred years and have never seen the likes of them. It truly violates ethical principles. I presume Jiang'er was also bewitched by the demon. Finding a man for her to marry and inherit the Jiang family early would be the proper thing to do."

"One can tell you've lived several hundred years - you're indeed quite antiquated," Jiuying said as she twirled her hair.

"Those two are..." Jiang Wuying's stern gaze swept over her, her expression unfriendly.

"Subordinates," Ning Fuyi replied.

"And this girl?" Jiang Wuying's suspicious gaze fell on Chu Qingqiu. She always felt the other party had extraordinary bearing, but couldn't identify who she was.

Ning Fuyi suddenly reached out and, taking advantage of Chu Qingqiu's inattention, interlocked their fingers and pulled her up from the chair, reaching out to wipe away nonexistent sweat.

"What do you think?" Ning Fuyi tilted her head toward Jiang Wuying, her hand still holding tightly. "Please prepare a room for us - we need to discuss a few things."

Jiang Wuying's face showed some blue-black color. She looked at their clasped hands as if looking at something glaring, her lips trembling for a moment before saying: "Dang Gui², take her there."

When the group turned to leave, she suddenly spoke again, but this time to Chu Qingqiu: "You appear to be from the immortal sects, but your actions should still follow proper etiquette. Don't let your youth lead you astray."

Seeing her target Chu Qingqiu, Ning Fuyi turned to confront her, but Chu Qingqiu suddenly stepped closer to her, her other hand also grasping her arm, seeming to link arms intimately.

Then she turned back, her cold gaze looking toward Jiang Wuying: "This junior is instructed."

Jiuying and Qiu Yi exchanged glances, and Jiuying covered her mouth, almost laughing out loud.

"What are you standing there for? Let's go." Chu Qingqiu pulled Ning Fuyi along, ignoring Jiang Wuying's expression, and strode out the door.

After entering the room and setting up a barrier, Jiuying finally burst into laughter, her waist twisting like water grass: "Girl? Divine Venerable is several hundred years older than her - speaking like that will probably shorten her lifespan! Little bird, your master has probably never heard such a tone before. With a changed face, she's also taken a loss!"

"She has heard it before," Qiu Yi said. "Years ago in Qi Kingdom³, you also spoke to her like that."

Jiuying stopped laughing.

Chu Qingqiu calmly withdrew her hand from Ning Fuyi's palm, lifted her skirt hem, and sat down properly: "Enough. Divine Physician Jiang's life and death are unknown, yet you can still play around?"

Then she looked at Ning Fuyi: "What have you thought of? Speak."

Ning Fuyi also became serious. She dipped her index finger in some tea water and drew the shape from the blood letter on the table. The water stains spread to both sides, and the more she looked, the more it resembled a winding snake.

"When Jiang Li wrote prescriptions, I saw her handwriting - every stroke was as forceful as a blade. Even if she were panicked, she wouldn't write in such a twisted manner. Combined with my knowledge of the snake woman incident, I always felt this blood letter depicted a snake."

"But they all say the snake woman is dead. Dead people can't just appear out of thin air, can they?" Jiuying frowned.

Ning Fuyi looked at her deeply, then pointed with her chin toward Chu Qingqiu.

"Oh, they can," Jiuying snapped her fingers.

Chu Qingqiu breathed out a longer breath, pretending not to hear their words.

"Then I remembered someone else. Thirty years ago when I was at the Jiang family, I was pursued by a Penglai person called Black Scales⁴. At that time, I noticed Jiang Li's strange reaction - she stared at that person for a long time and reacted strongly, as if she had seen them before."

"Later, with so many other matters, I didn't take it to heart. But thinking about it now, it seems suspicious," Ning Fuyi said.

"That Black Scales - I've fought with her. Her strength is unfathomable, unlike ordinary people. Even I fear her somewhat," Jiuying said, stroking her chin, her eyes shifting. "Are you suggesting that Black Scales is the snake woman from back then?"

Ning Fuyi shook her head: "I don't know about that. It's just that Penglai are all demigods. Apart from this Black Scales, I really can't think who else the snake could refer to."

"Perhaps it refers to a place?" Qiu Yi said softly.

"Jiang Li isn't that foolish. There are countless places that could be represented by snakes - Snake Island, Snake Mountain, Black Snake Sea, White Snake Spring. Since she left a blood letter, this snake's reference must be very specific."

After Ning Fuyi finished speaking, she looked at Chu Qingqiu as if seeking approval: "Am I right?"

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu nodded.

Ning Fuyi smiled and bumped Jiuying: "See if you can contact Yun Ke⁵ and inquire about that Black Scales - where she is now."

"Alright," Jiuying drawled, taking out a green feather from her bosom and channeling red light into it.

"It might take some time. Let's wait and see."

"Good. The medicinal smell here is too strong - I'm going out for some fresh air," Chu Qingqiu said, then left by herself.

The Jiang family manor wasn't small. Even in front of the guest rooms was a spacious courtyard. Chu Qingqiu stood under a flowering tree, smelling the flower fragrance for a while before feeling the medicinal smell dissipate.

She had originally wanted to check the surrounding situation, so she quietly expanded her divine sense. Seeing nothing unusual, she was about to withdraw it when she heard Ning Fuyi's name. The fingers at her chest clenched, grasping her lapel.

The discussion was between two immortal servants, one of whom was Dang Gui who had led them here.

She stopped sweeping fallen flowers and put her two thumbs together: "Did you see? That Cowering Hall leader Ning Fuyi and the beauty who came with her seem to be like this."

The other immortal servant covered her mouth: "Is it true or false?"

"Why would I lie to you?" Dang Gui continued sweeping while keeping her mouth busy. "I see they're quite intimate, but this Ning Fuyi has a terrible reputation. I heard she's promiscuous by nature, taking both men and women. All the attractive men and women in Cowering Hall have been touched by her."

The other immortal servant was even more shocked: "Is it true or false?"

"Can't you say anything else?" Dang Gui scattered fallen flowers at her. "That day at the Demon Slaying Conference, I followed along and saw with my own eyes her holding many beauties in her arms, each one a stunning beauty."

"The one she brought just now is also a stunning beauty. What a pity - she's fallen into evil hands." Dang Gui shook her head and sighed.

As soon as she finished speaking, a sudden gust of wind fell from overhead, blowing the previously swept pile of petals in all directions, causing the two immortal servants to scream and run about in chaos.

Chu Qingqiu hurriedly withdrew her divine sense and turned to see a tall, graceful woman in black standing on the steps, her charcoal-drawn eyebrows furrowed, her gaze piercing through the courtyard wall.

"Surrounded by immortals yet still daring to speak ill - not very bright," Ning Fuyi said lowly.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her, then turned her back to watch the falling flowers.

Ning Fuyi walked up behind her: "Divine Venerable wouldn't really believe it, would you?"

"I've taken another's appearance - no need to call me Divine Venerable," Chu Qingqiu said with her hands behind her back, speaking lightly.

"Then what should I call you? Surely not 'auntie' again," Ning Fuyi said, deliberately teasing her.

Seeing Chu Qingqiu remain silent, she obediently put away her smile and moved around to face Chu Qingqiu, circling her waist to take her hand, but the other party pulled her hand away: "Ning Fuyi, in the past it was I who avoided you, so whatever you did, I didn't care."

"But now that you and I have spoken plainly, if you act recklessly, I definitely won't forgive you!"

Footnotes:

1. **Eastern Wasteland (东荒)** - A desolate region often used as a place of exile or where dangerous beings are banished
2. **Dang Gui (当归)** - The immortal servant's name, which is also the name of a Chinese medicinal herb (*Angelica sinensis*)
3. **Qi Kingdom (岐国)** - A kingdom that was mentioned in earlier chapters where past events took place
4. **Black Scales (黑鳞)** - A powerful individual from Penglai, whose name suggests a connection to reptilian/serpentine characteristics
5. **Yun Ke (云客)** - A contact who can provide information, literally meaning "cloud guest"